

Robert E. Lee recognized the value of quasi-military units working independently behind enemy lines and answering to formal military authority. The most famous of these units was Colonel John S. Mosby's battalion of Virginia Partisan Rangers, which so terrorized Union authorities in northern Virginia that the area was referred to as "Mosby's Confederacy." Mosby repeatedly raided the B&O Railroad, attacked Union wagon trains, and tied down thousands of Union troops in garrison duty. Ulysses S. Grant was so bothered by Mosby's activities that in 1864, he ordered all captured Mosby partisans to "hang without trial," thereby violating the spirit of the Lieber Code.

1,200 The number of Union troops said to have been captured, killed, or wounded by John Mosby's partisan rangers by late 1864, although there were never more than 400 men in his command.



Recapturing a wagon train

Union cavalry recapture a wagon train seized by a Mosby raiding party. Guerrillas and partisan rangers operated behind enemy lines, using their intimate knowledge of the terrain to great effect.